

In Black & White



IN TEST: 10 LASER PRINTERS

Photograph: Rahul Sharma

A new breed of laser printers offers great print quality at lower prices. Are you set to utilise the laser advantage?

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Please don't rush out and buy a laser printer. If you are looking for a cheap solution for colour printing, if you intend to use your printer only occasionally, or if speed is not of the essence and quality is low on your priority list, we advise you to look elsewhere.

On the other hand, if you want impressive quality printouts and need to print thousands of pages in a month, you've come to the right place. The laser printer is a reliable workhorse that not only offers amazing speeds but also extremely low costs per page printed.

Laser printers have long been the mainstay of huge corporations and medium-level organisations because of their work capacity and output quality. Now they are turning out to be a feasible alternative even if you are a small office owner or work from home, with considerably lower prices and a wider range of options to choose from.

While inkjets offer a clear advantage price-wise, lasers continue to have the upper hand when it comes to print quality. The technology

they use ensures highly accurate printouts that are completely dry, so there's no scope for smudging. These printouts are water-resistant and will last longer than inkjet printouts without fading.

Lasers also have an edge over inkjets when it comes to handling non-regular media such as envelopes, cards, labels and tags. And though consumables are expensive, they are worth it—a single toner cartridge has the capacity of printing anywhere between 3,000 and 10,000 pages of excellent quality text.

Keeping the needs of SoHo users in mind, only black-and-white laser printers costing less than Rs 50,000 have been tested. These included 10 printers from six companies. Canon and Xerox were not able to participate, as they are on the verge of launching a new laser line-up, and they didn't want to send models that would be discontinued within a month's time.

Speed

When talking about laser printers, the first thing you generally think about is speed, especially if